

Figure I.14 *Tomb of Ghiyath al-Din Muhammad ibn Sam, Herat (addorsed to northern perimeter of Congregational Mosque), prior to destruction in 1944. From Glatzer 1980: fig. 12 (photograph R. Stuckert, 1942).*

elephant and the blind men of Ghur. Moreover, the methods for achieving empire were ad hoc and determined by specific circumstances, rather than prescribed beforehand.

Primarily – though *not* exclusively – relying on the Shansabanis' architectural patronage, the present work aims to reconstitute the proverbial elephant into a perceivable whole. It may appear contradictory, then, to pursue this aim in two volumes rather than one, but I believe this approach in itself presents an important opening. As the coming pages will show, the corpus of Shansabani foundations is datable by means of inscription, textual reference, and/or stylistic *comparanda* as falling within *c.* the early 1100s to *c.* 1215 CE – a corpus herein documented largely first-hand, analyzed, and also expanded. Such an architectural group permits a concentrated gaze on approximately eighty–ninety years of the mobilization of regional labor structures and the formation of new political hierarchies toward empire-building – an intimate entrée that is rare in the study of